

Chapter 20: Writing Your Research Report

Lab Report Structure, Discussion Sections, and Report Writing

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1 Overview

This chapter provides guidance on writing your Research Report — the final assessment for PS50008A. Your report follows the standard APA lab report structure.

2 Lab Report Structure

Your report should include the following sections, in order:

2.1 Title Page

- A clear, informative title that includes your key variables
- Your name and student number

2.2 Abstract

- 150–250 words summarising the entire study
- Includes: aim, method (brief), key result, conclusion
- Written last — after everything else is done

2.3 Introduction

- **Funnel structure:** Start broad (topic area), narrow down (specific theory and previous research), end with your hypothesis
- Define key terms and concepts
- Explain why this research question matters
- State your hypothesis clearly at the end

2.4 Method

- **Participants:** How many, how recruited, any relevant demographics
- **Design:** Between- or within-subjects, IV (with levels), DV
- **Materials:** What stimuli/measures you used
- **Procedure:** Step-by-step what happened (past tense)

2.5 Results

- Descriptive statistics (M, SD) for each condition
- Inferential test result in APA format
- A figure or table if appropriate

- State whether the hypothesis was supported

2.6 Discussion

- Restate your key finding (without statistics)
- Interpret what the result means
- Connect to theory and previous research from your Introduction
- Acknowledge limitations honestly
- Suggest future directions
- Brief conclusion

2.7 References

- APA format for all sources cited in the report

3 Writing Tips

1. **Start with Method** — it's the most straightforward section to write
2. **Then Results** — use your analysed data from Gordon
3. **Then Introduction** — build the argument for your hypothesis
4. **Then Discussion** — interpret your findings
5. **Abstract last** — summarise everything once it's written
6. **Proofread** — check APA formatting, spelling, and clarity

4 Additional Resources

- Lecture slides from Week 20
- APA results reporting guide from Week 19 lecture reading